

Shortly before retiring I visited Los Angeles, my home town. You've heard of Los Angeles. Woody Allen says Los Angeles's most important cultural achievement is that, in a car, you can turn right on a red light. Calvin Trillin says there's a theory that sooner or later anything in America that's any fun at all will be ruined by people from California. Raymond Chandler called Los Angeles a city with no more personality than a paper cup. Matt Helm, the jaunty, cynical secret agent created by Donald Hamilton, says that "Southern California drivers are a courageous lot. You might even call them reckless—perhaps life has lost its meaning down there without any real air to breathe."

Anyway, I told a cousin in Los Angeles that I was retiring. "I couldn't do that," he announced. "I'd go crazy if I had to sit on my butt all day."

Just what the hell *do* retired people do from Monday to Friday, while everyone else fights freeway traffic, drinks institutional coffee, and goes to meetings?

IMAGINE BEING RETIRED

Before retiring I insisted on having a clear picture of what my days would be like. I wanted to spell out my new life with the precision of last year's budget. What would I do in the morning? Would I put on a suit and go to the club for lunch? Would I memorize key lines from deodorant ads on TV? Would I take vacations? This last was very bothersome. After all, when you're retired you don't have any compulsory activity to vacate *from*. (I later found that I enjoy vacations as much as ever.)

I struggled with those questions before retiring, but I never came up with a typical day, month, or year. Instead, I made a list of activities, interests, places to visit, and the like. I listed things I *might* want to do rather than things I *would* do. I worked on the list over a six-month period before retiring.